

KEYWORDS — parenting, discipline, child development

I. THE SCOPE OF THE ISSUE

- UNICEF considers children globally to be in crisis: political violence, climate change, and poverty affect many children (UNICEF, 2024a; 2024b).
- In this time of crisis, parenting is one crucial area of focus.
- According to UNICEF data, $\frac{1}{3}$ of children are subject to physical punishment (Ward et al., 2023); $\frac{2}{3}$ to some form of violent punishment (UNICEF, 2024a).
- In a review of 50 years of literature on physical punishment, Gershoff & Grogan-Kaylor (2016) connect physical punishment to poor mental health outcomes, and other poor outcomes over the life course. Ward et al. (2023) examines the relationship of multiple forms of parental discipline to child outcomes.

II. ARE WE SIMILAR? ARE WE DIFFERENT?



Figure 1: positive parenting

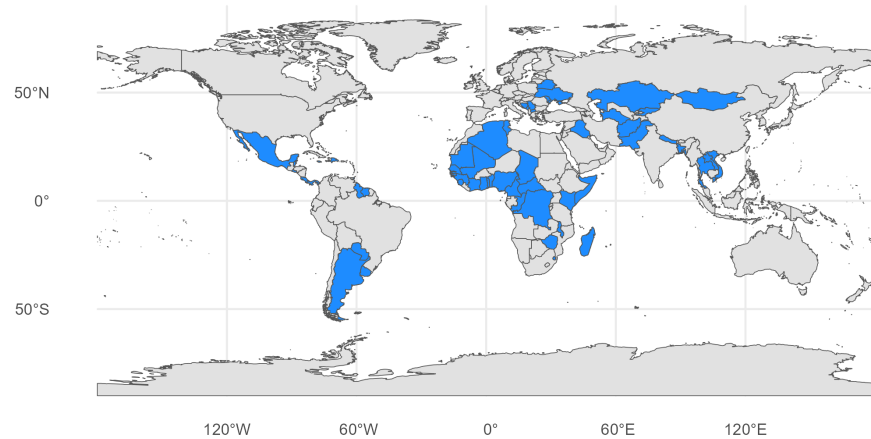


Figure 2: countries in MICS data

III. HIGHLIGHTING COMMONALITIES MAY PROMOTE INTERGROUP ATTITUDES AND SOLIDARITY

“Hanel et al. (2019) cite research suggesting that ‘highlighting similarities between groups improves interpersonal and intergroup attitudes.’ Others have argued that ‘build[ing] bonds of commonality across our differences’ might be an impetus for social transformation (Hunt-Hendrix & Taylor, 2024).”

IV. THE ARGUMENT

- Families, parents and children experience an incredible **diversity** of circumstances.
- Parents engage in parenting behaviors with consequent **diversity**, though with some **surprising similarities**.
- The associations of parenting with child outcomes are **surprisingly consistent**.

V. DATA

MICS data collected by UNICEF from Low and Middle Income Countries (LMIC) around the world. $N = 224,632$ families; $N_{countries} = 60$
Contains questions about parental discipline (both positive and negative) and child aggression.

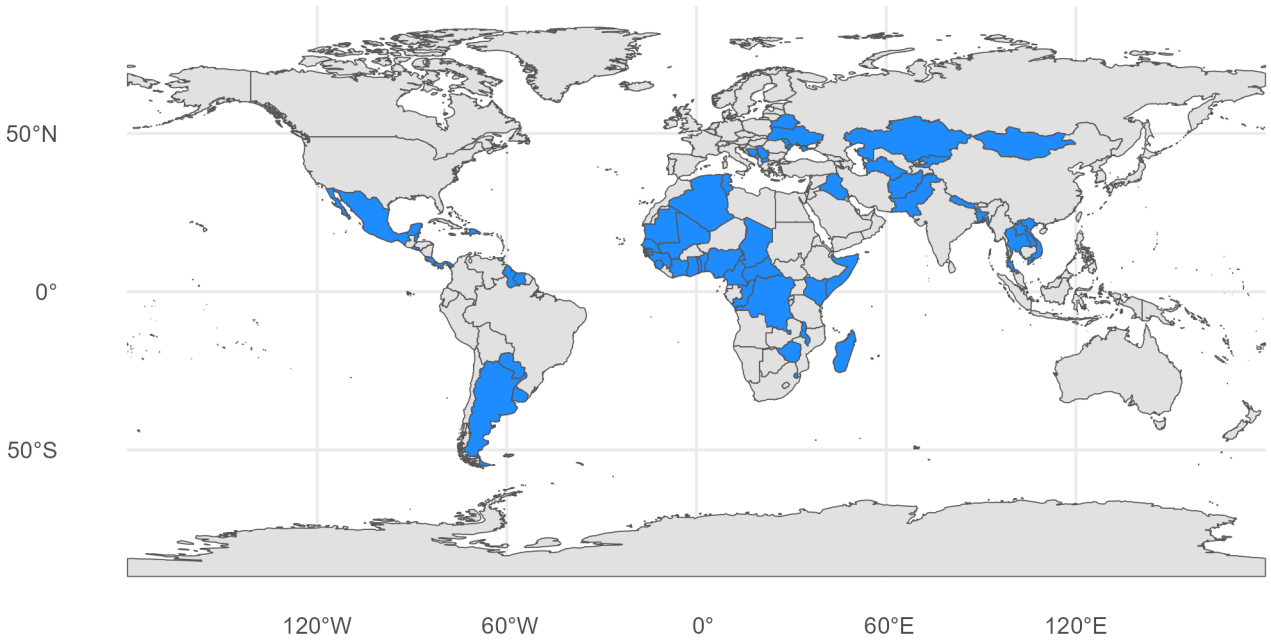


Figure 1: countries in UNICEF MICS Data

VI. SOURCES OF VARIATION IN THE STUDY OF PARENTING AND CHILD OUTCOMES

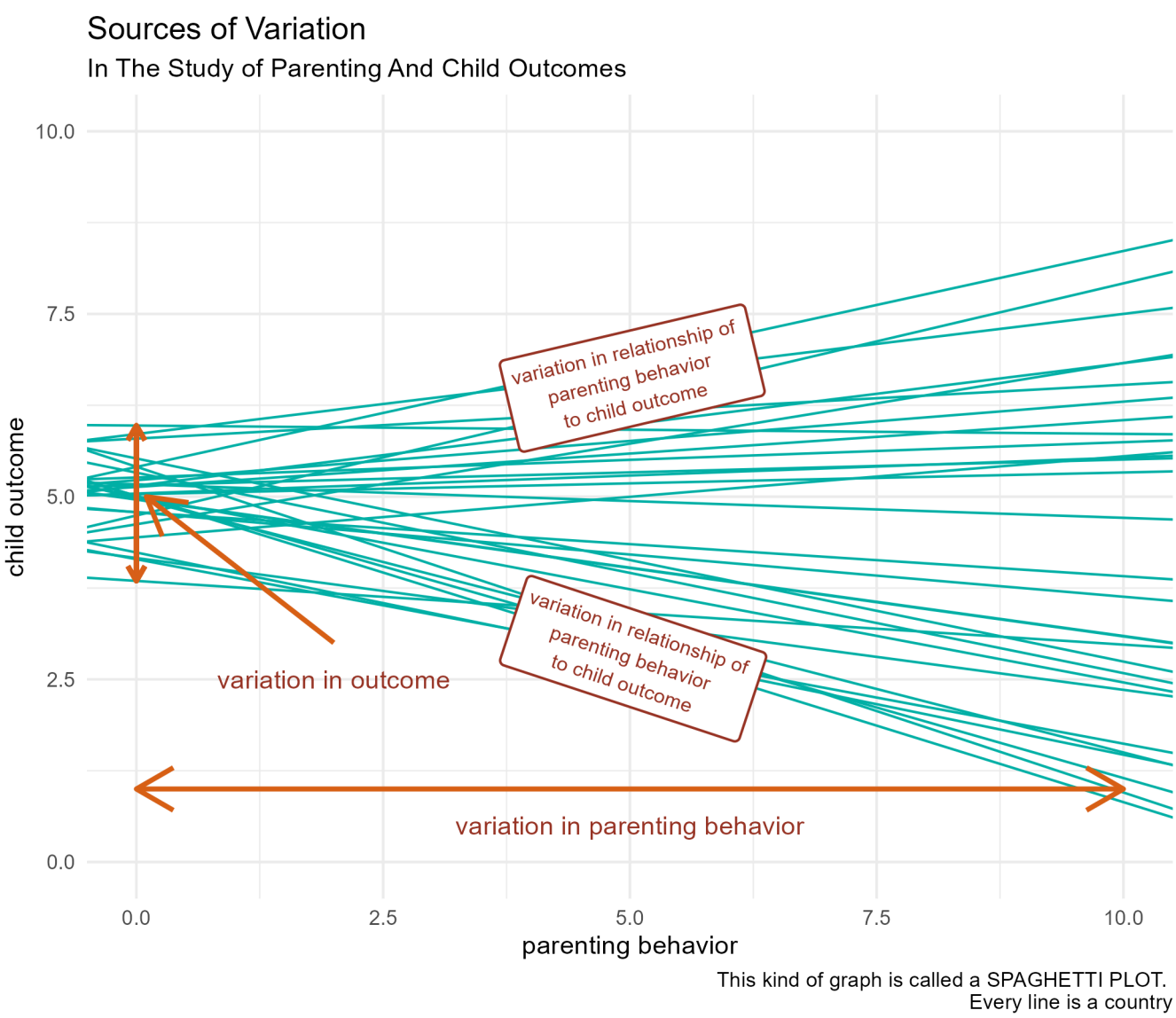


Figure 2: sources of variation

VII. PARENTING BEHAVIORS VARY SOMEWHAT ACROSS COUNTRIES

Verbal reasoning and shouting are the most common parental discipline behaviors toward young children.

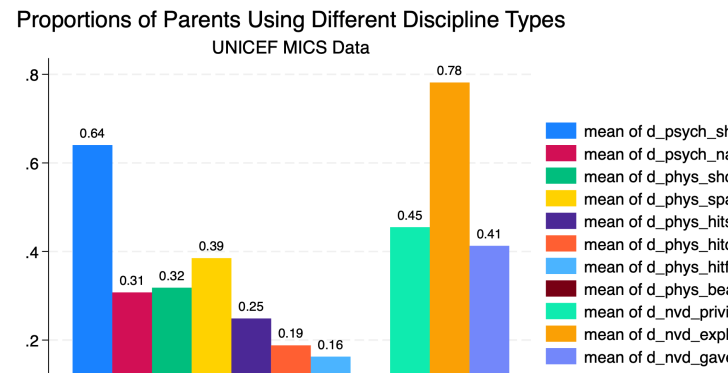


Figure 3: positive and negative parenting

VIII. A MODIFIED SPAGHETTI PLOT

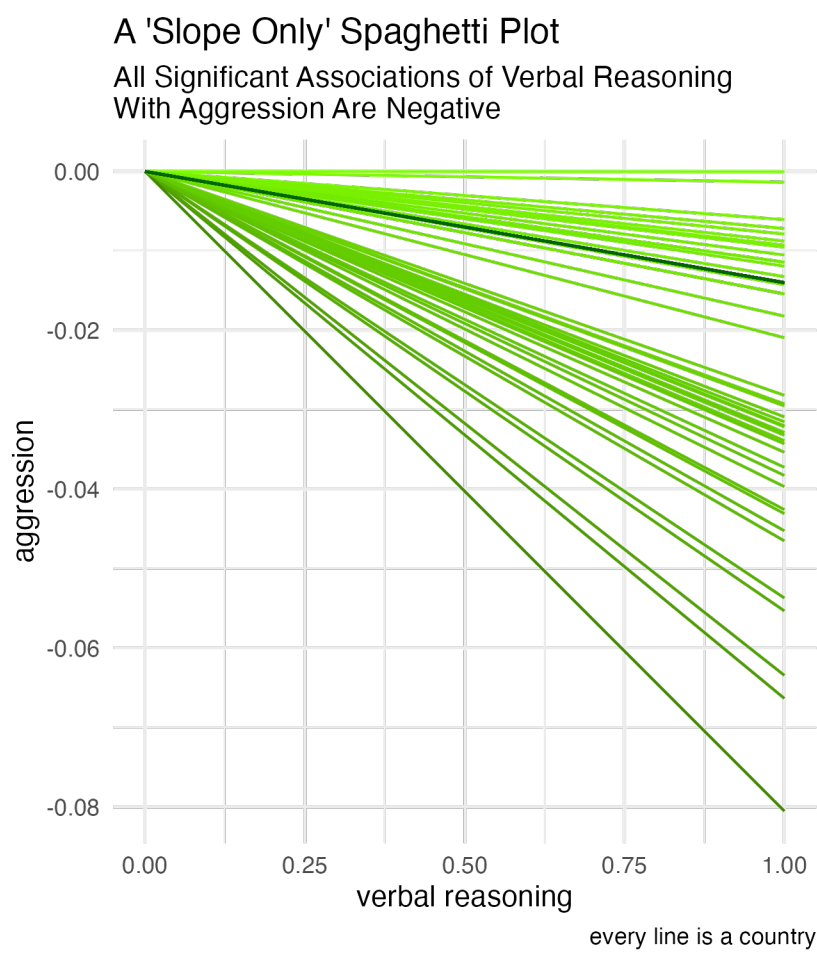


Figure 4: modified spaghetti plot

IX. TO SUMMARIZE ...

- There is an incredible diversity across countries, especially LMIC’s.
- However, the associations of different forms of parental discipline are surprisingly consistent.
 - Explaining to children the difference between right and wrong has consistently **“good”** outcomes in terms of aggression.
 - Spanking has consistently **“bad”** outcomes in terms of aggression.
 - Shouting has consistently **“bad”** outcomes in terms of aggression.
 - Name calling has consistently **“bad”** outcomes in terms of aggression.

BIBLIOGRAPHY

Gershoff, E. T., & Grogan-Kaylor, A. (2016). Spanking and child outcomes: Old controversies and new meta-analyses. *Journal of Family Psychology*, 30(4), 453–469. <https://doi.org/10.1037/fam0000191>
Hanel, P. H. P., Maio, G. R., & Manstead, A. S. R. (2019). A new way to look at the data: Similarities between groups of people are large and important. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 116(4), 541–562. <https://doi.org/10.1037/pspi0000154>
Hunt-Hendrix, L., & Taylor, A. (2024). *Solidarity: the past, present, and future of a world-changing idea*. Pantheon Books.,
UNICEF. (2024a, November). *FAST FACTS: Violence against children widespread, affecting millions globally*. <https://www.unicef.org/press-releases/fast-facts-violence-against-children-widespread-affecting-millions-globally>

UNICEF. (2024b, December). 'Not the new normal' – 2024 'one of the worst years in UNICEF's history' for children in conflict. <https://www.unicef.org/press-releases/not-new-normal-2024-one-worst-years-unicefs-history-children-conflict>

Ward, K. P., Grogan-Kaylor, A. C., Ma, J., Pace, G., & Lee, S. J. (2023). Associations Between 11 Parental Discipline Behaviors and Child Outcomes Across 60 Countries. *BMJ Open*. <https://doi.org/10.1136/bmjopen-2021-058439>